Experian Malaysia's State of Credit 2025 Reveals SME Resilience, But Cash Flow Strains Persist



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Despite improved payment behaviour, SMEs still face liquidity pressure as economic uncertainty grows.



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KUALA LUMPUR [21 May 2025] – **Experian Malaysia** (Experian) today released its *State of Credit 2025* report, highlighting emerging trends in payment behaviour and cash flow performance across Malaysian businesses.

Backed by Experian's Industry Debts Turned Cash (iDTC) data from its Malaysia Trade Bureau, the report measures credit repayment data across seven key sectors—construction, manufacturing, services, hospitality/F&B, transport/logistics, retail, and wholesale—providing a timely snapshot of the financial pulse of Malaysian enterprises.

Moderate Improvements but Payment Gap Widens

Malaysia's economy has shown steady recovery over the past two years, with GDP rising by 3.6% in 2023 and 5.1% in 2024. The construction sector led the rebound, growing by 14.6% in the first half of 2024 and a projected 13.7% in the second, driven by public infrastructure projects and strong private investments. The hospitality and F&B sectors also regained momentum due to a surge in international tourism.

This broader recovery supported a modest national improvement in payment behaviour. Insights from the report show payment delays across all enterprises fell from 64 days to 61 days over four years. SMEs showed slightly stronger improvement—reducing delays by five days, from 69 days in 2022 to 64 days in early 2025. Large corporations remained steady, averaging 58 days over the last three years with marginal improvement by just one day over the same period.

However, these gains are not evenly distributed. The gap between corporate and SME payment performance remains wide—particularly in sectors where supply chains are vulnerable, operational costs are high, and businesses face tighter liquidity. Many SMEs continue to navigate margin pressures, inflationary cost increases, and delayed customer payments, all of which challenge day-to-day operations and long-term resilience. In these environments, even small shifts in cash flow timing can have a significant impact on business continuity and growth, especially with recent economic challenges such as rising costs, subsidy reforms, and global trade uncertainties. SMEs in Malaysia could be more vulnerable, with liquidity being a significant challenge compared to larger corporations. As the economic environment becomes more unpredictable, SMEs may find themselves adopting a more cautious approach to cash

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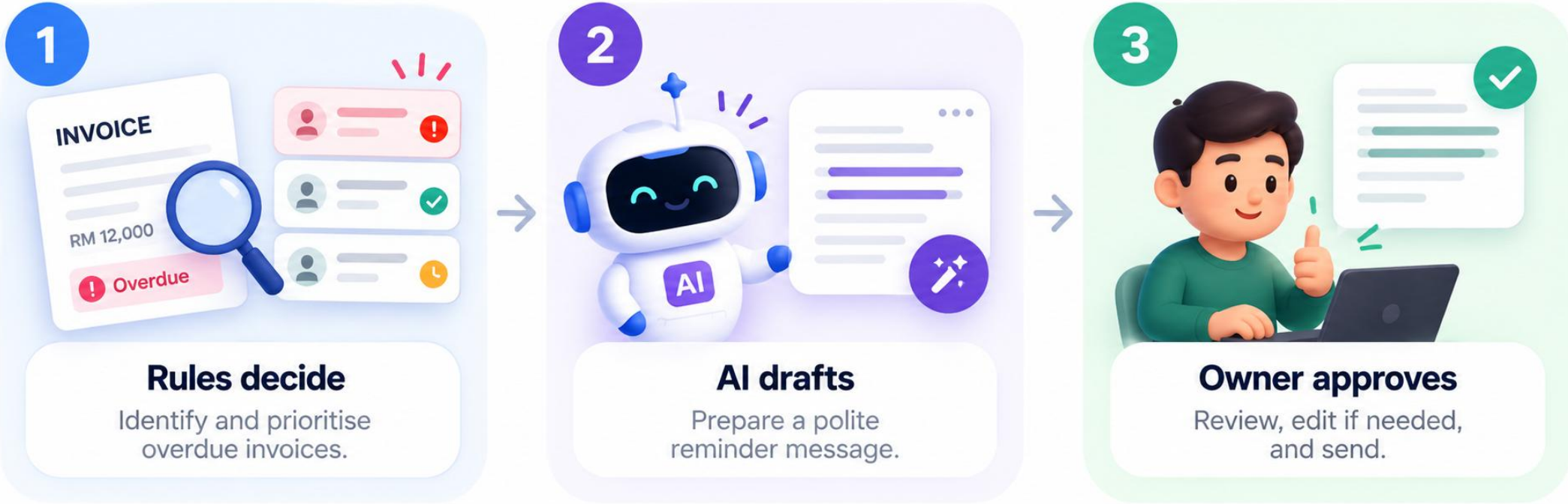
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BUSINESS IMPACTS

E-invoicing: Countdown to compliance for Malaysian SMEs

As Malaysia progresses with the rollout of its national e-invoicing initiative, businesses are required to comply in phases according to their annual revenue. While the shift to new processes can create challenges for businesses of any size, SMEs are facing unique hurdles of their own.

The third and fourth phases of the mandate, beginning 1st July 2025 and 1st January 2026, will directly impact a significant portion of SMEs – businesses that typically operate with fewer resources and tighter budgets compared to larger enterprises. Understanding what is required, along with selecting and implementing new technology, can feel like a daunting undertaking, especially with the ongoing pressure of balancing day-to-day operations and finances.

We spoke with 500 Malaysian SMEs for a pulse check on where they stand in the face of approaching deadlines. This whitepaper explores their understanding of the mandate, as well as challenges they're facing to meet its requirements. Ultimately, we seek to answer the question – just how ready are Malaysian SMEs for the nationwide transition to e-invoicing?



THANK YOU